STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE			PS-4300
	SARPY COUNTY SHERIFF'S OFFICE PAPILLION * NEBRASKA **GREG LONDON** **SHERIFF**	DATE ISSUED **06/06/23**	DATE REVISED	DATE REVIEWED 02/02/25
		APPROVED: *GREG LONDON*		
CHAPTER TITLE PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS	RESOURCES			
SUBJECT CHAPLAINCY THERAPY DOG PROGRAM	CROSS REFERENCE			

I. Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to establish the guidelines for the Chaplaincy Therapy Dog Program.

II. Policy:

Supervision of the Chaplaincy Therapy Dog Program is the direct responsibility of the Lead Chaplain. The Lead Chaplain shall ensure the health and welfare of the Therapy Dog, as well compliance with all policies and procedures.

III. Definitions:

A. Therapy Dog: Certified dog that has been trained for the purpose of providing comfort to employees and individuals in the community.

B. Therapy Dog Handler: Individual who is assigned to a Therapy Dog who has received training in how to deploy and care for a Therapy Dog.

IV. Procedure:

A. Cost, Care, Health, and Responsibility:

1. The Therapy Dog is privately owned and shall be the responsibility of the owner/handler for all feeding, watering, health, care, and hygiene needs. All equipment shall be provided by the owner.

2. The Therapy Dog Handler is fully responsible for the Therapy Dog as an owner/handler and the Therapy Dog is not considered property of the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office.

3. The handler shall utilize a licensed veterinarian to maintain proper immunizations and hygiene of the Therapy Dog. The handler shall also ensure that the veterinarian addresses any other health concern related to the Therapy Dog or its contact with the public.

4. The handler shall provide all certificates, proof of insurance, and proof of current vaccinations to the Assistant Professional Standards Commander/CALEA Accreditation Manager. The handler shall document any formal training.

5. The handler shall keep a log of deployment data.

B. Operational Guidelines:

1. Law Enforcement shall be notified and trained on the purpose and availability of the Therapy Dog by the handler.

2. The handler shall adhere to all policy and procedures set forth by each law enforcement agency regarding the use of Therapy Dog support while present at that agency.

3. When deployed in the office, the Therapy Dog Handler shall comply with the following restrictions:

a) Not allow the Therapy Dog to go anywhere it is not welcome.
b) Not relinquish custody of the Therapy Dog at any time.
c) Not permit the Therapy Dog to run free.

4. The handler shall take proper hygienic measures to ensure the cleanliness of the Therapy Dog to minimize any dander or residual hair that may be left by the Therapy Dog.

5. Any allergic/non-participatory staff member may declare their workspace or any common space they frequent a “no dog zone.”

6. Toileting shall be done by the handler in the south parking lot/greenspaces of the Sarpy County Sheriff’s Office where cleanup is easy and most hygienic.

C. Authorized Uses

1. Daily duties (extension of handler).
2. Public events.
3. Community outreach and engagement.
4. Major/traumatic incidents.
5. School demonstrations.

6. Grief loss and trauma.
7. Natural disaster incidents.
8. Victim forensic interviews.
9. Criminal investigations/interview.
10. Crisis intervention.
11. Medical facility visits (hospitals, nursing homes, VA clinics, etc.).
12. Staff wellness.
13. In partnership with government and non-profit organizations who address the effects of trauma, mental health, and crime.
14. Crisis intervention.
15. Any use not covered in this procedure as deemed appropriate by the Sheriff or his designee.

D. Public/Victim Visits:

1. Safety of the public/victim shall always be the number one concern of the Therapy Dog Handler.

2. The Therapy Dog Handler shall be the only one to handle the Therapy Dog throughout the facility or during a call for service.

3. Prior to the introduction of the Therapy Dog, the handler shall inform the potential recipient of the availability of the Therapy Dog, purpose for being present, and services provided.

4. Once permission is obtained from the recipient(s) of services, verbal permission shall be obtained from the individual(s) prior to introduction.

5. At no time shall the Therapy Dog be left unattended by the handler with staff or recipient(s) of services.

6. The handler will have been trained to recognize the signs of distress that individuals may exhibit when there is a concern regarding the Therapy Dog's presence.

7. The handler shall take appropriate actions to minimize contact with those who express their fear or show distress in the dog's presence.

8. Anytime an individual becomes uncomfortable with the presence of the Therapy Dog or exhibits behavior not conducive to the development of a relationship between the individual and Therapy Dog, the Therapy Dog shall be removed from the situation immediately.

9. Once removed, the Therapy Dog will not be reintroduced unless the individual requests it. If requested, the Therapy Dog Handler will go back over the purpose of the Therapy Dog's presence and ensure the purpose is

understood by all involved. Precautions and ground rules will be laid out for further participation in the Therapy Dog therapy program.

10. In the event the Therapy Dog must be removed from a particular situation for the second time, the Therapy Dog will not be introduced again.

a) Other more conventional forms of support shall be implemented in place of the Therapy Dog.

11. Any time the Therapy Dog exhibits behavior that alerts the trained handler that the Therapy Dog is uncomfortable, the Therapy Dog shall be removed immediately from the situation.

12. The Therapy Dog shall not be left unattended in any vehicle while representing the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office unless the vehicle is equipped with a temperature monitoring system.